3.3 Shot Heard Round the World

In 1837, American poet Ralph Waldo Emerson referred to a bullet fired in Lexington, Massachusetts, as "the shot heard round the world" in his poem "Concord Hymn." Nobody knows who fired that shot, but it started a revolution that changed the world.

MAIN IDEA The American Revolution began when Massachusetts militia fought the British forces in the towns of Lexington and Concord.

THE REVOLUTION BEGINS

As the British Army marched toward Concord, they heard church bells and saw lights in windows. The colonists were awake and aware. Soon after sunrise on April 19, the troops reached Lexington. There, they met about 70 armed militiamen, nearly half of the town's adult males. But the Lexington militia was inexperienced and faced a much larger British force.

The scene was chaos as both the British commander and the militia leader called orders to their troops. The British officer, Major John Pitcairn, wanted to disarm the Americans, not engage in battle. But as the British advanced, a shot rang out. Then there were several more. Pitcairn tried to stop his troops, but the shooting continued for 20 minutes, leaving eight Lexington men dead and 10 wounded. Only one British soldier was wounded and none were killed.

The British reached Concord at about eight o'clock in the morning. Using previously hidden military supplies, the Americans inflicted more casualties than the British did this time. The British soldiers attempted an orderly retreat back to Boston. But hundreds of militiamen fired at them from behind trees, walls, rocks, and buildings and forced many British soldiers to panic. The British countered by sending advance parties to set fire to homes and kill residents along the way back to Boston.

The fighting at **Lexington and Concord** is considered the first battle of the American Revolution. By the end of the day, British losses totaled 73 dead and 200 wounded or missing. The Americans counted 49 killed and at least 39 wounded or missing.

CHOOSING SIDES

As tensions between Britain and the colonies turned into open violence, colonists took sides in the conflict. Those who called themselves **Patriots** supported the right of the colonies to rule themselves. At first, not all Patriots wanted to separate from Britain. Over time, however, those on the Patriot side became convinced that independence was necessary.

The **Loyalists**, colonists who supported Britain, increasingly found themselves an uncomfortable minority. As time went on, it became dangerous to sympathize with the British cause. Some Loyalists were beaten or saw their homes burned by fellow colonists. In 1775, a Loyalist who spoke openly about his opinions was ordered to leave Maryland by the Maryland Provincial Convention.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the results of the fighting at Lexington and Concord?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the battles of Lexington and Concord increase tensions between Patriots and Loyalists?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What details support the idea that the Patriots won the battles?

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LOYALISTS CALLED THE **PATRIOTS**

Whig! Rebel! Yankee!

PATRIOTS CALLED THE **LOYALISTS**

King's Man! Royalist! Tory!



COLONIAL ARMY **SOLDIER**

BRITISH ARMY **SOLDIER**

FAMOUS **PATRIOTS**

- George Washington
- Thomas Jefferson
- James Madison
- Patrick Henry
- John Adams
- Alexander Hamilton
- Benjamin Franklin

FAMOUS **LOYALISTS**

- John Howe
- Mary Dowd
- Myles Cooper
- William Franklin
- Thomas Hutchinson

DAILY COLONIAL ARMY RATIONS

- 1 1/2 lb. Bread or Flour
- 4 oz. Whiskey
- 1 lb. Beef or 3/4 lb. Pork

DAILY BRITISH ARMY RATIONS

- 1 1/2 lb. Bread or Flour
- 8 oz. Rum
- 1/4 pint Canned Peas and 1 oz. Rice
- 1 oz. Butter
- 1 lb. Beef or 1/2 lb. Pork

COLONISTS VS BRITISH

ALLIES

France | Spain

United Netherlands

ALLIES

Many Native American Tribes

Hessian Troops



2.5 Million American Colonists

20% Supported Britain

11 Million People in Great Britain

2.5 Million Colonists in America

SOURCE: Civil War Trust Online

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